

Nigeria's NASSP-HUP at the Crossroads

An Independent Monitoring & Evaluation Review

What the framework promised. What the evidence shows. What it still cannot measure.

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THE BRIEF

This brief is an independent Monitoring & Evaluation review of Nigeria's National Social Safety Net Programme — Household Uplifting Programme (NASSP-HUP) — examining its stated development objectives, the indicators it commits to, the publicly available evidence of its performance, the gaps in its measurement framework, and the additional data approaches that would strengthen accountability and outcome verification.

PROGRAMME SUMMARY

NASSP-HUP (Nigeria) is a conditional cash transfer programme launched in 2016 under the National Social Safety Nets Programme, operated by the National Cash Transfer Office (NCTO) with World Bank backing (World Bank, 2016). Targeting poor and vulnerable households through a four-step Community-Based Targeting process and the National Social Registry (Premium Times, 2017), HUP aimed to reach 4 million households across 24 states with N5,000 monthly transfers, prioritising female recipients (85% target) (World Bank, 2016).

By 2019, as reported in World Bank implementation monitoring, the National Social Registry had captured 814,376 households across 28 states — reaching only 20% of the 4-million enrolment target — with electronic disbursement and 90% timely payment compliance (World Bank, 2019). Female recipients comprised 92–94% of the beneficiary base, surpassing the 85% target (World Bank, 2019).

Independent evaluations (Eluwa et al., 2025) found that while HUP increased savings and livelihood diversification, the fixed N5,000 stipend was severely eroded by inflation, with beneficiaries spending 26% less on food indicating worsened food security. The World Bank noted minimal employment impact, recommending complementary livelihood support (The Cable, 2024).

Systemic gaps include poor digital interoperability (only 1.6% of registered individuals held a valid NIMC number) (World Bank, 2019), COVID-era targeting failures documented by BudgIT (2020), and a N30 billion recovery investigation by the House of Representatives (The Cable,

2025). All four NSIP programmes, including HUP, were suspended in January 2024 by a Special Presidential Panel (Office of the President, 2024).

INTENDED OUTCOMES & OFFICIAL INDICATORS

The primary intended outcome of Nigeria's NASSP-HUP, as stated in the World Bank Project Appraisal Document (World Bank, 2016), is: "Provide access to targeted transfers to poor and vulnerable households under an expanded national social safety nets system." This outcome was to be achieved by expanding coverage to 4 million households in the National Social Registry (NSR), enrolling 1 million per year for conditional cash transfers (CCT) by 2021, across a minimum of 24 states (World Bank, 2016).

Official indicators and numeric targets from the same source include: 5 million direct beneficiaries (50% female); 4 million households in the NSR; 85% of transfer recipients being female; 24 states with signed MoUs; 24 states with operational social registries; 90% timely payments; 85% electronic transfers; and 90% of complaints resolved within three months (World Bank, 2016).

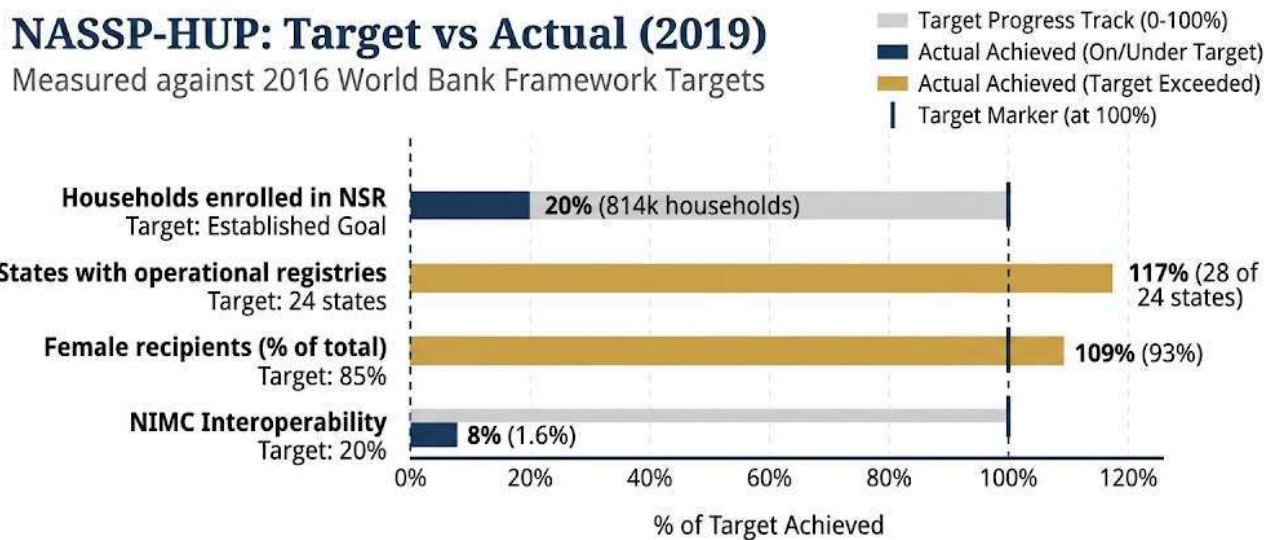
The NCTO's self-description (NCTO, n.d. ≈2023) offers only a generic objective — "targeted financial assistance to poor and vulnerable households" — with no quantifiable indicators. The broader NSPP framework (Federal Government of Nigeria, n.d.) lists ten policy objectives, including poverty reduction, empowerment against economic shocks, human capital development, protection from shocks, and lifecycle-based social protection — but lacks programme-specific metrics, making results verification reliant on the 2016 World Bank framework.

AVAILABLE EVIDENCE OF PERFORMANCE

Available performance evidence comes from World Bank implementation data, independent academic evaluations, and civic oversight reports. By April 2019, the National Social Registry (NSR) had captured 814,376 households (3.2 million individuals) across 28 states exceeding

the 24-state target but reaching only 20% of the 4-million household enrolment goal (World Bank, 2019).

Female recipients comprised 92–94% of the beneficiary base, surpassing the 85% target, and 94% of recorded grievances were resolved within the required three months (World Bank, 2019). Electronic transfers reached 302,676 households across 20 states by mid-2019 (World Bank, 2019).



A later World Bank impact evaluation (as reported by The Cable, 2024) found that households in early-entry communities showed larger increases in savings, food security, and farmland access compared to late-entry control groups. However, the scheme had “little impact on employment”, leading the Bank to recommend complementary livelihood support (The Cable, 2024).

“The 1.6% NIMC interoperability rate against a 20% target prevents deduplication, cross-programme coordination, and long-term tracking.”

An independent peer-reviewed study (Eluwa et al., 2025) tracking 150 households under the unconditional variant found that beneficiaries spent 26.1% less on food than non-beneficiaries indicating worsened food security. The study attributed this to the fixed N5,000 monthly stipend

being severely eroded by inflation. Positively, regular transfers enabled livelihood diversification (farming, petty trading) and improved access to banking and local safety nets (Eluwa et al., 2025).

Civic accountability evidence (BudgIT, 2020) documented widespread allegations of mismanagement during COVID-19 palliatives, noting that the NSR was inadequate for rapid scaling, opaque disbursement processes, and exclusion of urban poor and informal workers. More recently, legislative oversight (The Cable, 2025) reported that N30 billion had been recovered from NSIPA under investigation for misappropriation covering CCT and other social investment programmes.

Finally, in January 2024, the Presidency suspended all four NSIP programmes including HUP — for six weeks and established a Special Presidential Panel to investigate operations (Office of the President, 2024). At the time of writing, no public report from that panel has been released, leaving the programme's current performance status unclear.

GAPS IN THE M&E FRAMEWORK

The M&E framework for NASSP-HUP contains several critical gaps that undermine outcome verification and accountability.

- 1. Missing outcome indicators beyond process tracking.** The World Bank's (2016) results framework focuses heavily on output indicators (enrolment counts, payment timeliness, grievance resolution) rather than outcomes (poverty reduction, consumption smoothing, human capital gains). No indicator tracks multi-year poverty exit or intergenerational transfer effects.
- 2. No inflation- or purchasing-power adjustment mechanism.** Eluwa et al. (2025) identified a fundamental design flaw: the fixed N5,000 monthly transfer is not indexed to inflation. Their evaluation found beneficiaries spent 26.1% less on food than non-beneficiaries a perverse outcome indicating that the framework lacks a real-value maintenance indicator. This renders the programme's poverty-alleviation objective unverifiable over time.

3. Digital identity interoperability gap. World Bank implementation monitoring (World Bank, 2019) acknowledged that by mid-2019 only 1.60% of individuals in the NSR held a valid National Identification Number (NIMC), against a 20% target. This gap prevents deduplication, cross-programme coordination, and long-term beneficiary tracking — essential for any M&E system.

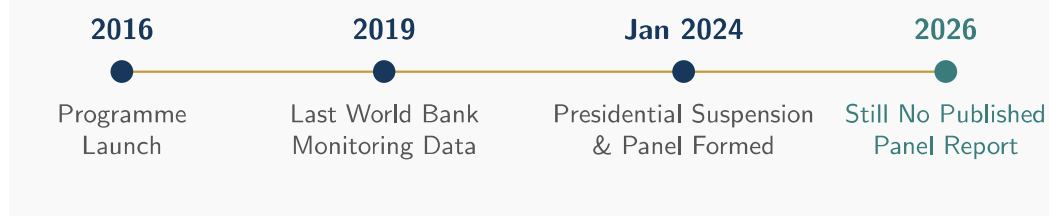
4. Targeting validity not independently verified. The Community-Based Targeting (CBT) process (Premium Times, 2017) relies on local committees, but no independent verification mechanism or “shadow” enumeration exists in the M&E framework. Akingbade (2020) raised the question: “what was the basis for capturing beneficiaries, and how will this category benefit?” — yet the framework contains no indicator for targeting accuracy (inclusion/exclusion error).

5. NSR inadequacy for shock response. BudgIT (2020) documented that the NSR could not scale rapidly during COVID-19, forcing ad-hoc, non-transparent palliatives. The M&E framework lacks indicators for system resilience or surge capacity a gap exposed by the pandemic.

6. Outcome evaluation irregularity. While two independent studies exist (The Cable, 2024; Eluwa et al., 2025), there is no mandated, regular, public impact evaluation schedule. The last World Bank implementation data is from 2019 (World Bank, 2019, June ISR). NSIPA’s own Chief Executive has publicly acknowledged that “not up to 30 percent of the population have been empowered” through the agency’s programmes since 2016 (The Cable, 2023) — an insider concession that compounds the absence of independent, regular impact monitoring.

7. Employment and livelihoods not tracked. The Cable (2024) reported the World Bank’s own finding of “little impact on employment,” yet employment status is absent from the official indicators a conspicuous omission given the programme’s stated empowerment objective.

The Four-Year Evidence Vacuum



RECOMMENDED INDICATORS & DATA

Strengthening the NASSP-HUP M&E framework requires the following additions, each addressing a gap identified above.

- 1. A real-value transfer indicator.** Replace the nominal N5,000 monthly transfer target with a purchasing-power-indexed transfer floor, expressed as a percentage of the federal minimum food basket cost. The indicator would track whether the transfer continues to represent a defined share of basic food security as inflation moves. This directly addresses the perverse outcome documented by Eluwa et al. (2025).
- 2. Independent targeting-accuracy audit.** Mandate an annual third-party audit of a randomly sampled 5% of beneficiary households to measure inclusion error (ineligible households enrolled) and exclusion error (eligible households missed). This addresses the unverified CBT validity flagged in Gap 4 and the COVID-era exclusion of urban poor noted by BudgIT (2020).
- 3. Multi-year poverty exit indicator.** Track the percentage of beneficiary households whose consumption rises above the national poverty line within two, three, and five years of programme entry. This converts the framework from output measurement (transfers delivered) to outcome measurement (poverty exited) — the missing link in the current results framework.
- 4. NSR-NIMC interoperability target with annual milestones.** Establish a phased target for the share of NSR-listed individuals holding valid NIMC numbers — for example, 30% by

end-2025, 60% by 2027, 90% by 2030 — with quarterly public reporting. This addresses the 1.6% interoperability rate documented by World Bank implementation monitoring (World Bank, 2019).

5. Public M&E reporting calendar. Mandate the publication of a NASSP-HUP performance dashboard at fixed quarterly intervals, with indicator-level actuals against targets disclosed to the public. This addresses the four-year evidence vacuum since the last World Bank monitoring round (Gap 6) and the still-unpublished findings of the 2024 Presidential Panel (Office of the President, 2024).

Together, these five additions move NASSP-HUP from a programme that measures what was done to one that can credibly measure what was changed — the defining transition between output tracking and outcome accountability.

From Output Tracking to Outcome Accountability	
Current Output Tracking	Proposed Outcome Accountability
Fixed nominal transfers (N5,000 target)	Real-value transfer floor (indexed to food basket)
Unverified Community-Based Targeting	Independent annual accuracy audit
Enrolment counts & payment delivery	Multi-year poverty exit trajectory
Isolated National Social Registry	Phased NSR-NIMC interoperability targets
Ad-hoc evaluations & unpublished panels	Fixed quarterly public performance dashboard

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